
HUNTBRIEF FIELD STUDY

BRAD HERNDON

DEER HUNTING METHODOLOGY

Mindset · Maps · Terrain · Routes · Wind · Choke Points

A detailed field study of how Indiana hunter, outdoor writer, and photographer Brad Herndon thinks about mature whitetails. Map-first scouting. The path of least resistance that stays in cover. Wind as the first filter. The full terrain library HuntBrief uses as Herndon logic — saddles, benches, points, inside corners, double inside corners, hilltop field funnels, converging hubs, breaklines, fencerows, and water pinches — plus how each feature maps onto the Anson County farm.

THE SIX-STEP OPERATING SYSTEM

1. Read the map before you walk — mark every choke point on paper.
2. Draw the easiest concealed daylight path through each feature.
3. Assign a legal wind. If scent cannot dump into dead space, kill the sit.
4. Enter across the field or off the back of the ridge — never across the trail.
5. Hunt high when the hills allow. Avoid swirling bottoms.
6. Trust the feature even when sign looks quiet. Terrain repeats; rubs do not.

Prepared for Casey Summerlin · Anson County, North Carolina
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*Drawn from Herndon's public writing, Mapping Trophy Bucks (2003), and published interviews.
Not a substitute for the book. Terrain tactics compiled from material he published.*

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This is a field study, not a reprint of Mapping Trophy Bucks. Tactics are compiled from material Herndon published or that reputable outlets attributed to him.

1. Who Brad Herndon Is — and Why His System Matters

Brad Herndon is an Indiana deer hunter, outdoor writer, and photographer from Brownstown, Jackson County. He has published hunting articles since 1987 in *Deer & Deer Hunting*, *Turkey & Turkey Hunting*, *Outdoor Life*, *Petersen's Hunting*, and *North American Whitetail*. For years he and his wife Carol shot national advertising photography for Realtree and Advantage camouflage. They hunted together, cooked wild game together, and treated the woods as a working pantry as much as a sport.

The book that put his name on HuntBrief stand recommendations is *Mapping Trophy Bucks: Using Topographic Maps to Find Deer* (Krause Publications / Penguin, 2003). He has said he wrote it around age 60. It became a hunting-category bestseller and is still the terrain text other teachers — Bill Winke included — point people toward. MeatEater's *Wired to Hunt* has recommended it alongside Winke's creek-and-ditch work as the pair of books that teach how deer relate to land.

The method is older than the book. Herndon has used maps to predict Midwest buck travel since about 1968. In the 1970s he watched fellow Hoosier Jay Mellencamp — uncle of John Mellencamp — pull a topographic map, point at a saddle, and explain how a trophy would cross it on the right wind. Herndon later found a subtle saddle on a map of ground he already knew, hung a stand where sign looked quiet, and saw eleven deer on the first December sit. He missed a 12-point that later scored 182. The feature was right. The rub line was optional.

He is not a television celebrity. He is a map nerd who lives off the land — squirrel is his favorite hunt and table fare; the family Pioneer Dinner of wild game ran for decades. Local papers still had him hunting in his late seventies. The personality matches the method: practical, patient, no mysticism. Read the paper. Sit the choke. Play the wind. Leave clean.

HuntBrief already names his system as the terrain engine for stand calls on the Anson County farm. Higgins answers when to go and how to keep a buck living on you. Lapratt answers how to zone a farm so daylight happens on your side of the fence. Herndon answers where the deer will put their feet when they do move.

2. The Core Mindset — How He Thinks About a Deer

Deer will use choke points during the daylight hours to avoid being seen and they'll try to travel from one place to another in the easiest manner.

— Brad Herndon, to Game & Fish

That sentence is the whole engine. A mature buck is sharp, lazy, and allergic to being silhouetted. Those three traits collide on a short list of landforms. Herndon hunts the collision.

Six beliefs he actually hunts by

- **Maps first, boots second.** You can mark several killable spots on a USGS topo or an aerial of ground you have never walked — including another state — before you leave the house. The woods confirm. They do not invent the plan.
- **Daylight travel is not random.** A shooter will not skyline a ridge, will not cut a wide-open field if he can stay just inside timber, and will not climb a steep face if a dip, bench, or drainage gives him an easier lane.
- **Sign can lie.** The best choke points often look quiet. Efficiency does not always leave a billboard of rubs.
- **Wind is the first filter, not a detail.** If the wind is wrong, the stand does not exist that day. Hunt high in hills. Avoid swirling gullies.
- **The same spot can produce year after year.** Carol killed mature bucks from one inside-corner stand across multiple seasons, including a midday sit in heat. Terrain does not move. Crops and pressure change.
- **The puzzle is the hunt.** He has said killing a giant is almost anticlimactic next to figuring out how to do it. An old deer is a sharp deer and hard to kill — which is the point.

He also insists the principles travel. Midwest, Canada, Mexico — body size changes; noses and laziness do not. A choke point works because daylight deer try not to be seen and try not to work harder than they have to. “The hunting principles are still the same.”

Two more attitudes show up in every profile. First, he still studies maps of ground he already knows, looking for the saddle or corner he missed. Second, he treats a personalized map as a hunt plan — stand pins, known sign, and the best wind written on the sheet — not as decoration.

3. How He Plans a Hunt — The Map Workflow

Herndon does not start with a tree. He starts with a sheet of paper, later a personalized digital map. The workflow implicit in the book and his Realtree writing is this.

Step	What he does	Why it sits here
1	Pull topo + aerial of the parcel.	Topo shows elevation choke points. Aerial shows cover shape — the L of an inside corner, the pinch of a timber funnel.
2	Circle every feature in the terrain library.	Saddles, benches, points, inside and double inside corners, hilltop field funnels, hubs, breaklines, creek and timber pinches, fencerows, dam crossings.
3	Draw the concealed path of least resistance through each circle.	Just inside timber, off the skyline, not across the open field. That line is the deer’s route, not the human trail.
4	Assign a legal wind to each stand.	If you cannot dump scent into dead space without crossing the trail, throw the sit out.
5	Design entry and exit that never walk the deer’s path.	Prefer coming across the field that forms the corner, or off the back of the ridge.
6	Mark stands, known sign, and preferred wind on the map.	The book’s later chapter on personalizing maps is the hunt plan, not a gadget demo.
7	Then walk. Confirm. Hang. Leave.	Maps keep you from walking a mile of unproductive ridge. They do not replace the woods.

Summer map work is not busywork. It is how you hang a December stand on a feature nobody else noticed. He has said you can get a topographic map of a place like Iowa and figure out several places to kill a big deer before you ever leave home.

4. How to Read the Paper — Contours, Aerials, Personal Maps

Contours

A topographic map is a drawing of steep and flat. Lines packed tight mean the hill drops fast. Lines spread apart mean a shelf, a saddle floor, or a hilltop. Herndon reads those spreads the way other hunters read rubs.

- **Saddle:** two high points with a dip between them. Contours form two separate closed shapes, or pinch-open-pinch along a ridge.
- **Bench:** tight lines above, two or more lines farther apart on the shelf, tight again below. A very narrow bench will not print. You find that one on foot.
- **Point:** contour U or V pointing downhill into a bottom or field. The tip of the U is where trails often cross.
- **Steep face / bluff:** lines stacked so tight they almost touch. Deer rarely travel the face. They go around, over a saddle, or along the bench above it.
- **Hilltop field funnel:** a drainage (V-shaped contours pointing uphill) that dies at a hilltop opening. The neck between field edge and first contours of the drain is the sit.

Aerials

Aerials earn their keep on flat ground, where contours lie. Look for timber shaped like an L or a C against a field. Look for a thin strip connecting two woods. Look for a swamp that bulges and leaves a timber sliver against a pasture. Look for a fencerow or ditch that ties two blocks together. Those shapes are inside corners and funnels. They do not always show as elevation.

Personalizing the map

Herndon's "dot-com" chapter was about marking the sheet so it becomes a plan: stand locations, deer sign, and the best wind for each tree. HuntBrief's named pins and wind notes are that chapter applied to one farm. A map with no wind written on it is only a picture.

5. Routes and Paths — The Movement Model

He does not treat "a trail" as the plan. He treats destination + resistance + cover + wind as the plan. Night trails across the middle of a field are not the hunt. The hunt is the 40 yards of timber where the buck refuses to step into the open.

A typical Herndon path

- Bed on a bench, a point, a thick inside-corner pocket, or the leeward side of a ridge.
- Drop or climb via a saddle or drainage rather than the steep face.
- Stay just inside timber along a field — never exposing across the open corner.
- Hit a funnel (creek, fencerow, timber pinch, hilltop field neck) between bedding and food.
- Arrive at soybeans, a food plot, or mast. Pressured deer often do this after legal light. Rutting bucks use the same geometry in daylight.

Morning and evening are the same geometry with the arrows reversed, plus thermals. Rising morning thermals can lift scent up a face. Falling evening thermals dump scent downhill. Do not sit above bedding if your scent will wash into it at last light.

How he thinks about "routes" versus "paths"

A route is the larger line from bedding block to food block. A path is the specific thread inside that route — the inside of the L, the downwind edge of the saddle, the neck of the hilltop drain. Most hunters hang on the route and miss the path. Herndon hangs on the path. That is why a stand 40 yards off a field edge, inside timber, beats a stand on the field itself.

He wants those arrows drawn on the map before a stand goes up. If you cannot draw the path, you do not have a stand. You have a tree.

6. Mastering the Wind and Thermals

Wind is chapter two of the book for a reason. Terrain without wind is a pretty drawing. His doctrine is simpler than modern thermal-mapping talk, and stricter than “sit downwind of the scrape.”

Rules he hunts by

- Hunt high in hilly country so the wind is predictable. Low funnels and gullies swirl and bust you.
- On an inside corner formed by a field or pasture, place the stand so the wind whisks scent back out into vacant open ground. The deer cannot smell where you entered.
- The same wind must serve the walk and the sit. A clean sit with a dirty walk is a dirty sit.
- Do not hunt a beautiful funnel on a swirling day just because the map looks perfect.
- Mark the best wind on the map next to the stand.
- Use morning and evening thermals instead of pretending they do not exist. Rising air in the morning can carry you up a face. Falling air in the evening can dump you into a bed.

Most often a field or pasture forms this inside corner and this provides a perfect entry to stand for a smart deer hunter who wisely uses the wind. The deer can't smell where he has entered his stand, plus the wind whisks his scent back out into the vacant field or pasture. It's an awesome — and often overlooked — setup.

— Brad Herndon, Realtree (from Mapping Trophy Bucks)

He learned the hard way in swirling gully funnels. The feature concentrated deer — and concentrated his scent in every direction. After that, height and a dead-space dump became non-negotiable.

Practical wind pairs on mixed ground

Feature	Wind that usually works	Wind that usually kills the sit
Inside corner against a west field	Wind into the field (often W / NW / SW depending on which way the L opens)	Wind that blows from the stand into the timber the deer are using
Saddle on a north–south ridge	A quartering wind that lets you sit one shoulder and dump off the back	A wind that runs the saddle like a tube and carries you to both approaches
Bench on a west face	Wind slightly off the face so scent lifts or slides away from the travel line	A hard wind that pins scent to the bench trail
Creek funnel in a bottom	Only if a breeze is steady and you can sit a bank that dumps downstream into unused cover	Calm mornings and swirling October bottoms
Hilltop field funnel	Wind that blows from the neck out into the hilltop field	Wind that blows down the drainage into bedding

If you cannot name the dump — the empty field, the back of the ridge, the unused downstream bank — you do not have a Herndon wind. You have a hope.

7. The Full Terrain Library

Each feature is a place where the path of least resistance and the need to stay hidden occupy the same few yards. That overlap is the stand.

Feature	What it is on the map	How deer use it	How he sits it
Perfect funnel	Narrow cover connecting two larger blocks.	Daylight highway. They feel hidden.	Downwind fringe, not mid-trail. Do not walk the pinch.
Hilltop field funnel	Drain from a hilltop field down to a valley. Neck is field-edge to first drop.	Hard-used trail in that neck.	Access through the field. Dump scent into the opening.

Feature	What it is on the map	How deer use it	How he sits it
Saddle	Dip in a ridgeline. Contours pinch, open, pinch. “Hottest spot in the hills.”	Easiest crossing, off the skyline.	Conservative downwind edge until you learn the favored side.
Bench	Flat shelf on a face. Tight / spread / tight contours.	Travel the length of the hill; often bed here.	Shoulder of the shelf. Learn thermals. Worth the extra work.
Inside corner	Timber like the letter L. One inside corner, five outside.	Round the inside of the L just inside timber.	Inside cover at the tip. Enter across the field.
Double inside corner	Two inside corners close together.	Tighter squeeze around a jutting field.	Same rule, two jogs. Cover the wrap.
Point	Ridge finger dropping into a bottom, field, or creek.	Work down the finger; often cross at the tip.	Downwind shoulder, not the skyline spine.
Converging hub	Several ridges or drains meet like spokes.	Trails stack.	Gun can sit the hub. Bow picks one spoke.
Breakline	Seam where two cover types meet.	Travel the edge.	Offset downwind. See both sides. Do not stand in the seam.
Fencerow	Covered strip connecting timber blocks.	Highway, including hilltop fences between two woods.	Do not walk the fence. Blind if trees are wrong.
Water / dam	Swamp bulge, stream edge, pond, dam crest.	Walk-around or dam-top crossing.	Either end of the crest or the thin timber sliver.
Field saddle	Low spot in an otherwise open field.	Lowest, least-exposed line when they must cross.	Only if cover or crop gives them a reason to use it in light.

Book chapter order is itself a lesson: tools, then wind, then the perfect funnel, hilltop field funnel, saddle, bench, cutting corners, double inside corners, points, converging hub, breakline bucks, fencerow phantoms, then where the giants live, then how to personalize maps.

8. Inside Corners and Field Edges — His Signature Play

This is the flat-land and field-edge play most hunters get backwards. They sit the outside corner or the field itself. The buck is already inside the woods cutting the inside corner.

How to see it

Picture timber shaped like the letter L. You can count five outside corners and only one inside corner. When deer travel in daylight they take the inside of the L just inside the timber because it is the shortest route from one wing of woods to the other — and they stay concealed. Inside corners with large tracts of timber on each side usually carry the most traffic.

How to hunt it

- Stand inside cover, covering the trail that hugs the edge as it rounds the tip of the corner.
- Enter across the field or pasture that forms the corner. Do not cross the timber trail.
- Let the wind dump into vacant open ground so the entry trail never gets winded.
- A double inside corner (two jogs close together) tightens the squeeze further.
- Do not hang on the outside point of the woods that juts into the field. That is the place a buck can see you, and the place he will not walk in daylight if he has a hidden wrap.

Carol’s multi-year inside-corner stand is the proof of concept he used in print: same tree, multiple mature bucks, including a midday November sit when most people had already written the morning off. The feature was doing the work. The clock was secondary.

On a soybean year — which 2026 is on this farm — inside corners get louder. Beans do not hide a crossing the way standing corn does. The buck who wants to stay hidden has to use the L. That is a Herndon year to hunt the timber wrap, not the

middle of the field.

9. Hills: Saddles, Benches, Points, Hubs

Hills intimidate hunters because they look complicated. Maps make them simple. Herndon treats hill country as a set of obvious choke points once you can read contour lines.

Saddles — “the hottest spot in the hills”

A saddle is a low spot in a ridgeline. Deer cross here because it is easier than going over the high points and because they stay off the skyline. Wind up high is predictable, which is why he ranks this above pretty bottom funnels. Sit the conservative downwind fringe. Broad saddles make deer favor one side; you will not know which side until you sit or glass. Do not stand in the exact center and hope.

Benches

A bench is a flat shelf partway down a face. Wide ones show on a topo. Narrow ones — old logging roads, subtle shelves — you find on foot. Deer travel benches lengthwise and bed on them. Wind slides the face with thermals; it takes a few sits to learn a given bench. He called that extra work worth it. His biggest bow deer came from one.

Points

A ridge finger dropping into an opening or creek is a natural drain for travel. Deer work toward the point and often cross at the tip. Hunt the downwind shoulder, not the spine, so you are not skylined and so scent does not blow across every trail feeding the point.

Converging hubs

Where several ridges come together, trails stack. Firearm hunters love the extra yards. A bowhunter has to pick the one spoke the deer actually use and sit the downwind edge of that spoke, not the hub itself.

10. Funnels, Breaklines, Fencerows, Water

The perfect funnel

Classic pinch of cover connecting two larger blocks. Herndon spends a whole chapter making funnel hunting better, not just naming the feature: wind, trail location, stand placement, approach, and when the funnel is worth a sit. A funnel you walk through to reach the stand is no longer a funnel. It is an education program.

Hilltop field funnel

Formed when a creek or drain runs from a hilltop field down to the valley. The kill zone is the short neck between the field edge and where the drainage starts. A heavily used trail often sits in that neck. Access through the field. Wind advantage is the whole point of being on top instead of in the bottom.

Breaklines

The line of demarcation between two cover types — hardwoods to cedar, pine thicket to oak, crop to CRP. Deer travel seams. A hunter standing on the seam is standing in the trail. Offset downwind, see both habitats, let the deer choose the edge.

Fencerow phantoms

Heavy fencerows connecting woods — especially hilltop fencerows linking two timbered hills — are covered highways. A friend of his missed a Boone and Crockett deer on one. Ground blinds show up here because the trees are often wrong. Walking the fencerow itself is how you blow it.

Water and dams

A swamp that bulges toward a woods can leave a thin strip of timber between water and a field — a ready-made pinch. Streams, ponds, and lakes force walk-arounds. A dam crest is an overlooked crossing: deer use the top of the dam to get from one side of the water to the other. A tree on either end of that crest can be enough.

11. Stand Placement, Entry, and Exit

Herndon's stand is not “the big oak by the scrape.” It is the tree that lets you see the concealed path of least resistance without standing in it, on a wind that dumps into nothing the deer use, reached by a walk that never crosses that path.

Piece	His standard
Tree location	Downwind fringe of the feature — inside-corner tip, saddle edge, bench shoulder, funnel shoulder — not the middle of the trail.
Height in hills	High enough that wind is clean. Low swirling air is a veto.
Scent dump	Empty field, pasture, or downhill dead space. Never into bedding or into the travel lane.
Entry	Across the field that forms the corner, up a creek the deer do not use at that hour, or off the back of the ridge.
Exit	Same rule in reverse. Busting one deer on the way out can burn a feature that would have produced for years.
Reuse	If the landform is still there, the sit is still valid. Change wind and season phase, not the feature.
What he does not build first	He is not a habitat architect in the Higgins or Lapratt sense. He reads what the land already built, then hangs a tree that does not ruin it.

Entry cookbook

- Field-formed inside corner: walk the open ground, stay off the timber edge until you are at the tree, climb, let scent blow back into the same opening.
- Hilltop field funnel: same idea — the field is the road. Do not drop into the drainage and climb back up the deer's trail.
- Saddle: come up the back side of the ridge, stay off the skyline, drop into the downwind shoulder.
- Bench: come from above or from a face the deer do not travel at that hour. Do not walk the bench itself to the tree.
- Creek funnel: use the unused bank or a downstream approach. Do not splash the crossing they use.

You can add architecture later — hinge cuts, screens, sprayed trails. If you skip the map, the architecture is decoration.

12. Sign, Scouting, and What He Ignores

Herndon is not anti-sign. He is anti-sign-as-the-plan. The saddle with quiet dirt still produced eleven deer. The inside corner with ordinary tracks still produced mature bucks across seasons. Sign tells you a deer was there. Terrain tells you where the next one has to go.

What he underweights

- Rub lines as the primary stand picker.
- Hunting the middle of a big wood with no pinch.
- Sitting outside corners because they “look like a field edge.”
- Walking miles of ridge hoping to bump into a pattern.
- Treating a swirling bottom funnel as a gift.
- Assuming midday is dead if the feature is the only hidden shortcut between two blocks.

What he overweights on purpose

- Contour lines.
- The shape of timber against fields.
- Drainages leaving hilltop fields.

- Any place two cover types meet.
- Any place a deer can stay hidden while taking the short way around.

Speed-scouting new ground is the practical payoff. Drawn for a new unit, hunting a new permission farm, or looking at Anson County from the kitchen table — mark the L-corners, saddles, creek pinches, and hilltop necks first. Then walk those circles. That is the whole point of the book.

13. Seasonal Application

Herndon is a terrain man, not a weather-calendar man. The feature does not change in October. The reason the deer use it does.

Window	How the same feature works
Early season	Food-to-bed geometry. Inside corners and hilltop field funnels shine when soybeans or plots are the destination and deer still want cover on the walk.
October	Same pinches, fewer daylight hours of use if heat and pressure stack. Do not abandon the feature. Wait for a wind that matches it.
Rut	Bucks cruise the same concealed shortcuts while covering ground. Saddles, hubs, creek crossings, and inside corners become seek-phase stands. Average October trees can become great; pretty field-edge October trees can die.
Late season	Destination food plus the shortest hidden walk to it. Hilltop field funnels and creek corridors between bedding and leftover grain or plots.
Off-season	Map study. Hang or confirm trees on features, not on last year's rub. Personalize the map.

Midday is not automatically dead. Carol's November inside-corner kill happened after noon in heat because the buck was still using the concealed shortcut. If the feature is the only easy hidden path between two blocks, the clock matters less than people think.

14. Mistakes He Is Trying to Save You From

Mistake	Why it fails	The Herndon fix
Hanging on the outside field corner	Daylight bucks wrap inside timber.	Sit the inside of the L.
Walking the funnel to the tree	You educate every deer that uses the pinch.	Enter from the field or the back of the ridge.
Sitting a swirling bottom because it "looks like a funnel"	Scent goes every direction.	Hunt high, or stay home.
Abandoning a quiet saddle	Efficiency does not always advertise.	Trust the contour. Confirm once. Hunt the wind.
New tree every year	The landform did not move.	Change wind and season phase, not the feature.
Scouting by walking every ridge	You invent pressure and still miss the pinch.	Circle features on paper. Walk only those circles.
Treating night field trails as the hunt	Mature bucks did that in the dark on purpose.	Hunt the 40 yards of timber where he refuses the open.

15. The Six-Step Operating System

Strip away the magazine bylines and the Realtree ads, and this is the machine.

Step	Action	Failure mode if you skip it
1	Read the map before you walk — mark every choke point.	You walk unproductive ridges and educate deer you never needed to meet.

Step	Action	Failure mode if you skip it
2	Draw the easiest concealed daylight path through each feature.	You hang on sign that is a night trail or an outside corner the buck will not use in daylight.
3	Assign a legal wind. Scent must dump into dead space.	A perfect saddle with a dirty wind is a wasted sit and a taught deer.
4	Enter across the field or off the back of the ridge — never across the trail.	You hunt your own entry stream. The feature is burned before legal light.
5	Hunt high when the hills allow. Avoid swirling bottoms.	The funnel concentrates deer and your scent in every direction.
6	Trust the feature even when sign looks quiet.	You abandon the stand that would have produced for years because it did not look “hot” on a Saturday walk.

A primary HuntBrief stand should answer four questions in one sentence: What choke point is this? What is the concealed path of least resistance today? Does today’s wind dump scent into dead space? Can you walk in without crossing that path? If any answer is no, it is secondary — or a sit to avoid.

16. Stand-by-Stand Read of the Anson County Farm

Locked facts: 308.44 acres in Anson County, North Carolina (35.076243, -80.193882), Central Deer Zone. Large ag fields are soybeans in 2026. Blue circles are fall food plots. Orange pins are the thirteen named stands. The table below is a Herndon lens, not a claim that every pin sits on a textbook feature. Use it to force the four questions before a briefing names a primary.

Stand	Likely Herndon feature	Path to look for	Wind / access test
Pine Thicket	Breakline (pine vs hardwood) and possible bench or saddle in northern timber.	Deer traveling the seam or a shelf rather than the thicket interior.	Do not walk the seam. Dump off the back of the ridge or into unused pine.
Braswell Back	Inside / double inside corner against northeast ag.	Wrap just inside timber around the soybean L.	Enter across the field. Scent into vacant beans.
Braswell Midway	Same field-edge family, mid-north.	Shorter wrap between two timber wings.	Same field-entry rule. Wrong wind turns it into an outside-corner bust.
Papa Bob	Interior timber — only a sit if a saddle, bench, or breakline is real.	Concealed shortcut between west cover and fields.	If you cannot name the choke, it is a tree, not a Herndon stand.
GaGa Woods	West-central timber. Breakline or small funnel between woods and fields.	Edge travel, not the middle of the block.	Access off the field or the back side. Do not cut the block.
Upper Food Plot	Plot-edge inside corner and possible hilltop-field neck if a drain leaves the plot.	Hidden wrap from bedding to the plot, not the plot center.	Walk the plot or the field, not the timber trail into it.
Lower Food Plot	Same family, lower plot.	Second L or pinch between plot and creek timber.	Soybean year favors the wrap. Corn year would hide a crossing you cannot see.
Upper Creeks	Creek funnel / drainage finger.	Daylight crossing or bank trail between blocks.	Only on a steady wind that dumps downstream into unused cover.
Martys	South-central — saddle or interior funnel if the contour dips.	Shortcut between southern timber and fields.	Confirm the dip on a topo before treating it as a saddle.
Papa Darin	Southeast interior near creek influence.	Link from interior cover to the creek system.	Do not approach down the creek the deer use.

Stand	Likely Herndon feature	Path to look for	Wind / access test
Drews	Southeast near creek — bank pinch or creek-to-field funnel.	Hidden line from bed to beans or plot.	Creek access only if it is the unused bank.
Bottom Creek	Classic creek-corridor funnel.	Daylight highway in the lower corridor.	Swirl risk. Hunt it high on the bank or skip it on calm mornings.
Papa Bobs Hill	Point / hilltop field funnel candidate.	Trails working the point or the neck where a drain leaves the hilltop.	Hunt the downwind shoulder. Enter from the field on top, not up the face.

Soybeans in 2026 make Braswell corners, both food-plot wraps, and any hilltop-field neck louder than they would be in standing corn. Corn hides a crossing. Beans expose it. Hunt the L.

17. How This Stacks With Higgins and Lapratt

Question	Herndon	Higgins	Lapratt
Starting point	The map and the landform.	The sanctuary and whether the buck lives on you.	Beds first. Zone the farm so daylight happens on your side.
What he builds	A personalized map and a tree on a choke point.	Screens, sprayed trails, rope scrapes, 360 blinds.	A maze of small visual zones, beds, and paths that steal time.
Wind	First filter. Hunt high. Dump into the field that forms the corner.	Play the wind the way the buck plays it. Stay home if walk and sit are not both clean.	Design so the buck never smells a hunt. Pressure is the enemy of the 90%.
When to go	When the feature and the wind agree.	When temperature, front, wind, and that buck's window agree.	When the maze is holding him and you are not burning the only clean walk.
Sign	Optional confirmation. Quiet dirt on a saddle is still a sit.	Cameras map multi-year windows. Yesterday's plot photo is a trap.	Beds and daylight use beat plot pictures of 1.5-year-olds.
Best use here	Which of the 13 stands is the choke point today.	Whether you should leave the house, and whether the walk is still clean.	Whether the farm is holding the buck in daylight or leasing him to the neighbor at dark.

They stack. Lapratt asks if the farm is built to hold him. Higgins asks if today is a day to climb. Herndon asks which tree is the path. HuntBrief already names Herndon logic on stand recommendations. Use the other two studies so weather, sanctuary, zoning, and discipline have a home too.

18. Sources and How to Go Deeper

This study is compiled from Herndon's publicly available work and from reporting that quotes him. It is not authorized by Penguin Random House or Krause, and it is not a transcript of Mapping Trophy Bucks.

- Mapping Trophy Bucks: Using Topographic Maps to Find Deer (Krause / Penguin, 2003) — the primary text. Chapter spine: tools, wind, perfect funnel, hilltop field funnel, saddle, bench, cutting corners, double inside corners, points, converging hub, breaklines, fencerows, giants, personalized maps.
- Brad Herndon, "How to Use Topographic Maps to Find Deer," Realtree (2016 reprint of book material) — inside-corner definition, Carol's stand, wind dump into the field.
- Realtree staff, "Scouting for Deer with Topo Maps" (2019) — saddle, hilltop field funnel, bench, hub, dam funnel, fencerow language consistent with the book.
- Lynn Burkhead, "Summer Map Study Can Lead to Big Buck Riches," Game & Fish / OutdoorChannel — Mellencamp origin story, quiet-saddle sit, 182-inch miss, "easiest manner" quote.
- Contemporary reviews (Bowhunter / Free Library and others) listing hilltop field funnels, field saddles, breaklines, converging hubs, cutting corners, double inside corners.
- Seymour Tribune and Indiana Public Media profiles (2021–2022) — Brownstown life, Carol, Pioneer Dinner, living off the land.
- MeatEater Wired to Hunt, "How to Use Terrain and Topography to Hunt New Properties" — recommends Herndon with Winke as core terrain reading.

If you want the methodology from the man himself, buy the book and mark the Anson County map with his chapter list. This PDF is a map of how he thinks. It is not the woods.

End of field study

Prepared September 9, 2026 · For personal use on the Anson County property and HuntBrief planning.